

BITTERNESS IN POLITICS"

society and we don't look up to playboys.

Q. Tell us something about the relationship Benazir and you shared.

A. First of all, we started the relationship in an arranged marriage. And in our society, in arranged marriages, we have a bond of oneness and at the same time there's respectability. We respected each other, we respected each other's space, we were an extension of each other. I instantly knew what she was thinking even in jail, what she would say or which direction she was going and vice versa. She could read,

"EVEN IF THE PPP WINS A TWO-THIRD MAJORITY WE WOULD HAVE A GOVERNMENT OF NATIONAL CONSENSUS."

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write and think my responses. We were constantly in each other's spirit.

Q. Did Musharraf's Government have a role to play in Benazir's assassination?

A. We in PPP feel that the government, to say the least, holds some responsibility. By putting forward different theories, the government is trying to muddy the water. Why is it rejecting the plea for an UN probe? It knows the incident is one of the largest in the history of South Asia.

Q. Do you think the elections are going to be fair or rigged?

A. The international monitoring authorities have already given a verdict

that they have been rigged. There's pre-poll, polling day and post-poll rigging. Pre-poll rigging has already taken place. Then there are certain steps to be taken for a free and fair elections that we had wanted. If the methodology hasn't been followed then obviously they are not going to be free and fair.

Q. Why go into elections which you know will not be free and fair?

A. We take precedents from our history. When our late founder and leader Shaheed Z.A. Bhutto was in the death cell, the then dictator had called for an election and PPP had decided to go for it. Then he (Zia-ul-Haq) ran away from it. We find strength, lesson and wisdom from our history; and PPP has a long history of confronting dictatorships and being at the receiving end, having martyrs and how to act after such tragedies. We are following our history.

Q. PPP has been at loggerheads with Nawaz Sharif. Do you think you can form a coalition with him?

A. I think the need of today in Pakistan is a national consensus government. Even if PPP and I have to go back to my colleagues for this policy, win two-third majority or a simple majority, the need of the hour is that we should have a government of national consensus. There's too much of divide, too much of fragmentation and too many issues to handle. It will have to be a collective nation with collective responsibility to face the situation—to face the aftermath of this election.

Q. You have no bitterness towards Nawaz Sharif who had you jailed when he was in power?

A. We cannot afford bitterness in politics. We never have. PPP has never held that energy as useful. We don't hold anything against anybody. Our late leader Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto has been known to be working and has worked with all adversaries and managed to overcome all odds in difficult circumstances.

Q. Will you then be working with President Musharraf?

A. The party has decided we will face the situation once we are in the

assembly and once we have gone through the elections. We don't want to be part of the problem, but we would like to be part of the solution.

Q. If PPP has a two-third majority, will you impeach Musharraf?

A. Like I said, we will come to the bridge and cross it. We will go back to the party and take collective wisdom from it.

Q. So you are not ruling it out.

A. I'm not ruling it in either.

Q. What would be the priorities once your party takes over?

A. Economy and nation building.

Q. What about tackling religious extremism?

A. We have no choice. Either we do that or don't survive as a nation. Nobody wants Pakistan to be a Taliban state. Nobody wants warlords here. These are also carpetbaggers of war which is also a business.

Q. What is the view of PPP about the political role the army has been playing in the last 10 years?

A. PPP has maintained that the army has only one job—looking after the borders of the nation and the situation where civilians can't look after. The whole of Pakistan Army is close to a million man army including the paratroopers and other forces. The officer cadre in it is just 6 per cent and they are also not totally collectively involved in governance. Only a few are involved in it. So how can a few rule a country of 175 million people? The army should return to the barracks.

Q. Coming to relations with India would you have a different approach than what Musharraf has?

A. The government for the last eight years has just been play-acting whether it is economic reforms or peace process with India or fight against terrorism. Like in Indian movie terms, they only have a trailer but no movie. Benazir Bhutto has left us a legacy which she started in 1988, and it was close relations with India and a powerful SAARC.

Watch a telecast of the interview on

Headlines Today on Friday (7:30 p.m.) & Sunday (1:30 p.m.)

